
Critical Thinking — Self Reflection Journal

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Q1. Identify the biases that you are now able to relate to in your past experience. List the top three biases.

The three that I related to the most were confirmation bias, anchoring bias and groupthink.

Confirmation bias I've definitely done — when I already had an idea of how to solve something, I'd look for things that agreed with me and kind of ignore the rest. Anchoring happened a lot in effort estimation meetings, whoever spoke first would set a number and the whole discussion would just revolve around that number. Groupthink is the one I felt most guilty about — there were a few times I sat in meetings where I felt something was off but since everyone else seemed fine with it, I just went along. Looking back I should have spoken up more. These were things I was doing without even realising they had names.

Q2. Did you catch yourself when you went through Fast (Non-Conscious) Thinking and Slow (Deliberate) Thinking? Share your experience.

Yes, honestly more than I expected.

Fast thinking happens a lot during production issues. Something breaks and I immediately jump to what I think is the cause based on what's happened before. Sometimes it's right, sometimes it wastes a lot of time because I wasn't actually checking, just assuming. Slow thinking is what happens when I'm writing something important or making a decision that affects the team — I naturally slow down and think it through more carefully. What the module made me realise is that I wasn't really choosing between the two, I was just falling into whichever one felt natural in that moment. Now at least I notice it happening, which feels like a small but useful shift.

Q3. Do you think eliminating emotions completely would be the right way to think critically? Share your experiences.

Honestly no, and I used to think the opposite.

I always associated good analytical thinking with being detached and purely logical. But thinking about it more, emotions do give you signals. That uneasy feeling when a design

doesn't seem right, or when something a stakeholder says doesn't add up — that's worth paying attention to. The problem isn't having emotions, it's when they take over completely and you stop questioning anything. I've seen both extremes — people making big calls purely on gut and skipping any real analysis, and people being so focused on logic that they completely ignored how their decision would affect the people around them. Neither worked well. The more balanced version is what actually leads to better decisions.

Q4. Pick a problem or bug that you worked on a few months back. Now with this new awareness, how would you define the problem statement better? Which method helped you define it better?

We had API timeouts affecting some partner integrations. At the time we just said "fix the gateway" and spent almost a week on it before realising the actual issue was somewhere else entirely — in the adapter layer.

If I were to define that problem today I would have asked more questions before jumping to solutions. Things like — is this happening for all partners or specific ones, at what point exactly is the timeout happening, has anything changed recently. The 5 Whys method is what I think would have helped the most here. It forces you to keep asking why instead of stopping at the first obvious answer. We basically stopped too early last time and it cost us a lot of time. That problem is a good reminder of how rushing the problem definition ends up slowing everything down.